

Carving a niche: Athletic Club, based in Bilbao, has won 35 domestic titles, making it the third-most successful club in Spain. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT / LA LIGA

honor. "We play with just Basque players. Those who are born or formed in Basque country. The first criterion is easy. The second is: What does it mean to be formed here? The player or the family has to come to the Basque country for natural reasons like work," says Gonzalez.

The Basque country comprises seven provinces spread across Spain and France: Biscay, Gipuzkoa, South Navarre, Alava, North Navarre, Soule, and Labourde.

"We are around two-and-a-half million people. Out of this, how many are professional players? Our market is small, so our investments are for our academy. We invest a lot in coaches and scouts," says Gonzalez.

Athletic has established a feeder line for its first and second teams through its youth academy in Lezama. This academy has tie-ups with 160 local clubs, ensuring that it never runs out of talent. This apparatus has been in place for 125

years, contributing to the club's 24 Copa del Rey crowns and three Super Cups, as well as their eight league wins.

"Just the opportunity to show the world that with this unique philosophy, we can fight against the best teams in Spain and the world," says Gonzalez.

As one moves closer to the Pyrenees, the ideology diverges. Donostia-San Sebastian is the third-largest city in the Basque country, situated in the Gipuzkoa province. It is also the home of Athletic Club's arch-rival, Real Sociedad. Real Sociedad followed a 'Basque-only' philosophy until 1989, when it signed Liverpool's John Aldridge. "We have a different way of doing things. Our academy is open to the whole world. We know that with 720,000 inhabitants [in Gipuzkoa], staying in the football elite is impossible. We must be able to attract players," says Luki Uriarte, director of grassroots football with Real.

The club's leeway yielded rich dividends when its academy, Zubietta, produced French international Antoine Griezmann. Arriving in the Spanish coastal city, aged 14, from Burgundy, France, Griezmann worked his way up the ladder before

moving away to Atletico Madrid in 2014.

"Griezmann has always been very clear in his statements that he is grateful for the work that Real did. It is very endearing. Technically, he was brilliant. He had good vision but lacked the strength to dribble away from trouble. We had to take good care of him," says Uriarte, who was Griezmann's coach at Real's Under-15 and Under-16 teams.

Even as Real allows foreign talent to walk through its gates, it holds on to its resolution to give back to the region. Its board ensures that 80% of the talent in its associate clubs is from Gipuzkoa. The number eventually drops to 60% in its academy's age-group teams.

"Our only policy is that our doors will never be closed for players from our community. The rest in our hands is to provide service to the players so they make it to the first team. We have a board of directors who believe in the grassroots system. We have a first-team coach who is willing to play them. We have to prepare them to take that leap. We are a modest club compared to the others in La Liga. When the players feel they can achieve something else at a different place, they are free to leave," says Uriarte.

